For this reason, Swaran Singh has been described as ‘the “forerunner” of his nephew Bhagat Singh’, [15] who was also imprisoned in Lahore Central Jail and also died aged twenty-three. Bhagat Singh would have been just three years old at the time of Swaran Singh’s death. What would certainly have been impressed upon his mind indelibly would have been the presence in the family household of Swaran Singh’s grieving widowed wife, Hukam Kaur, who went on to live for fifty-six years, alongside Ajit’s wife, Harnam Kaur, who was no less destitute of the affections of her exiled husband. Hukam Kaur and Swaran Singh had no children. The only daughter of her parents and the only sister of several brothers, she lost all faith in life. Virendra Sindhu, Bhagat Singh’s niece, records her as having bewailed, ‘*Mujhe kya diya hai Bhagwan ne, jo main uski pooja karoon / Sirr parr patti naheen, gaud mein santaan nahi*’ [16] (‘What has God given me that I should worship Him / my protection is gone, and my womb is barren’). Bhagat Singh was acutely aware of the painful circumstances of his two aunts and in particular of the widowed Hukam Kaur. His first letter written in his native tongue Gurmukhi sees him, in 1921 at the age of fourteen only, writing from Lahore informing her about a picture of his uncle Swaran Singh that he had been working on, explaining that ‘Chachaji’s portrait is almost ready. I was supposed to bring it along, but it could not be completed by then; so please forgive me.’ [17] Bhagat Singh only wrote two letters in the Gurmukhi language. Both were written to Hukam Kaur. Another, written the following month in November 1921, refers to her as ‘my dearest chachiji’ (meaning aunt) and asks for her forgiveness because ‘I’ve got delayed in writing the letter’. [18] Such was the deep obligation he felt towards her, even at such a tender age, while still at school.